In

1896, SHORTLY AFTER Bombay was hit by a devastating plague, civic officials went on a clean-up mission. How could they remake the city to ensure a similar epidemic did not strike again? One outcome was the Dadar Parsi Colony in the slowly expanding north of the old city. With streets laid out radially, short boundary walls and adequately distanced quarters, the quaint, low-slung complexes emerged out of strict regulations on light, ventilation and overall sanitation. This is among 18 projects being showcased at a new exhibition in Mumbai tracing the knotty, evolving history of the city's building bylaws and the Bombay they birthed.

(DE)CODING MUMBAI showcases 18 projects from the colonial south to the fast-growing exurbs

"We have come full circle," says Sameep Padora, founder and principal architect of Sp+a, the firm behind *(de) Coding Mumbai*, the exhibition. "The first bylaws were created to better living conditions, now we are at a point where our bylaws enable unhealthy living conditions."

It all began four years ago when a builder approached Padora's firm to design an affordable housing project on the outskirts of Mumbai. As they began studying existing housing in the city, a question kept resurfacing. "What we were asking ourselves, is what prevents older models of housing from being built today? The kind we felt work well in terms of light and ventilation and creating socio-cultural fabric," says Padora. "The straightforward answer is that a lot of our building codes won't allow for these kinds of projects to be built today. The next question became, how did the building codes turn out the way they have?"

Building regulations in the city are laid down by the civic body and govern the macro and the micro environments we live in. How many elevators should a building have? What should be the minimum width of a common corridor? What should be the length of protruding balconies? Together, they determine land use, the shape of our skyline, how we interact with our neighbours, the places we call home.

The exhibition showcases projects from the colonial south to the fast-growing exurbs. It stretches across time, starting in 1898, post-plague, going up until today. Over a century, we see how the city has taken shape as bylaws have evolved. From neat town plans to organic urban sprawl, from slum resettlement projects to multi-storey parking schemes. Take one study, the 'Mushroom Tower', in Mahim, where six residential floors squat uneasily atop a slender plume of seven parking floors, thanks to what Padora describes as "perverse incentives" for development. "Regulations have gone from defining the quality of life to being tied only to quantifying the commercial considerations of land value."

The exhibition will continue at IF.BE, Ballard Estate, Mumbai, until June 25, and will also travel to Ahmedabad and Bengaluru later this year. A book detailing the 18 projects will also be released in August. ■

- Bhavya Dore

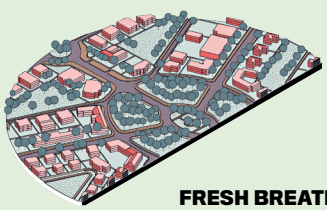
ARCHITECTURE

HOW MUMBAI WAS BUILT

A new exhibition traces the history of Mumbai's building bylaws and the city they have shaped









FRESH BREATH
Houses in the Dadar Parsi colony in Mumbai